Key Messages

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- The good spatial-temporal distribution of rainfall in both 2017 growing seasons (the Primera and Postrera) contributed to the best staple grain harvests in several years by farmers in the region's Dry Corridor. With their grain reserves from these harvests and the employment opportunities in agro-processing industries for coffee, sugar, tobacco, and market garden produce, households in Dry Corridor areas should experience **Minimal (IPC Phase 1)** food insecurity for the entire outlook period.
- The worst-off households with little if any crop production from this growing season and for several consecutive years due to rainfall anomalies will remain **Stressed (IPC Phase 2)** throughout the outlook period. Most of these households are concentrated in southern and southwestern Honduras, eastern and western El Salvador, and parts of northern and central Nicaragua.
- The reportedly high rainfall rates between September and November affected crops in highly localized crop-producing areas across the region, producing delays and, in some cases, requiring the replanting of crops. The hardest hit households lost their crops to pests and diseases as a result of the excessive rainfall. The areas reporting the most damage are crop-producing areas in valleys, along the banks of rivers, and in coastal areas of Honduras and Nicaragua.
- The current La Niña conditions expected to extend through the second quarter of 2018 (April through June) should help ensure the good progress of Apante/Postrera Tardía crops, though they also pose a risk of crop damage from excessive rainfall in certain parts of the region.

REGIONAL CLIMATE OUTLOOK

The above-average rainfall activity during the developmental and harvesting stages of Postrera crops in major crop-producing areas of Central America (Figure 1) was conducive to good crop growth and development. However, while there is still no official data available, it is possible that the excessive rainfall may have affected bean production in certain localized areas. Current rainfall conditions bode well for the planting of Apante/Postrera Tardía crops,